

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 20

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: A scientist alone at a polar research station discovers, slowly, that a blizzard has cut her off from the world.

1

The satellite link had gone down at sixteen minutes past three, which I knew because I had been waiting for the daily transmission and had been watching the cursor blink on the terminal. One moment it was blinking; the next moment the screen sat back in its frame and offered me, with the calm indifference of all broken machines, a single grey error code. Outside, the wind that had been merely loud since lunch had begun to do something more deliberate to the building, leaning on the walls in long, considering pushes, as though testing what they were made of.

2

I did what I had been trained to do. I logged the time of the outage. I checked the back-up modem, which was dead. I checked the secondary antenna, which was dead in a different and more interesting way. I noted the wind speed — forty-eight metres per second and rising — and the outside temperature, which had fallen, in the past two hours, by nineteen degrees. Then I made a cup of tea, because the protocol for storms says, in so many words, that the scientist should remain warm and unhurried. The protocol is a wise document. I drank the tea slowly. I did not, just yet, think about the word **alone**.

3

The station, when it is full, holds eleven people. There are three sleeping pods, a laboratory, a generator room, and a kitchen with a window that, in summer, looks out across a long blue plain of ice. In winter the window looks out at nothing in particular. The other ten members of my team had flown out on the last supply aircraft six days earlier; I had volunteered to stay behind to finish a series of atmospheric measurements that would have been ruined by their departure noise. The decision had felt, at the time, simple and rather noble. It was beginning, now, to feel less so.

4

I imposed upon myself the small disciplines of routine. I made the bed I had not slept in. I cleaned the

kitchen surface that was already clean. I reread, aloud, the emergency procedures pinned beside the door, not because I had forgotten them but because the sound of my own voice in that quiet was a steadying thing. I read them with a teacher's clarity. I corrected my own pronunciation of **carabiner**. The wind, outside, did not seem to mind.

5

At eighteen-twenty, the generator stuttered. It is the sort of small mechanical hesitation one would barely notice on a normal evening — a brief dip in the lights, a half-second of silence from the ventilation fans — but in that place, at that moment, it was the sound of every comfort I had pausing to consider whether it wished to remain. I stood up so fast that the chair fell over behind me. I did not pick it up. I went into the generator room, holding a torch I did not need, and I stood beside the machine and listened to it the way one listens to a sleeping child whose breathing has briefly changed. It steadied. It returned to its low, settled hum. I do not remember what I said to it. I remember that I said something.

6

Afterwards, the panic drained out of me with such suddenness that I had to sit on the floor for a moment. The fear had been pure and short and useful: it had reminded me what I had, and what I might still lose. When I stood up again, I was quieter than I had been all day. I went back to the kitchen. I made another cup of tea, and this time I tasted it.

7

The hours that followed were strange and, in their way, peaceful. The blizzard outside was performing a serious and ancient piece of work, and I, inside, was a small warm thing performing my own. I wrote up the morning's readings in long hand because the printer was down. I cooked a careful, modest supper. I read three chapters of a book I had brought from home and had not yet opened. Twice I stopped reading because the wind, in a particular gust, sounded almost like a voice; I noted, each time, that it was not, and went back to my page.

8

The satellite link came back at four minutes past two in the morning. There was a brief, friendly chirp from the terminal, and a queue of messages from the mainland began, politely, to download. I looked at the screen for a long time before I answered any of them. I had spent eleven hours as the only human being for six hundred kilometres in every direction, and I had not, on the whole, been bad company.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator describes the broken machine as offering her, “with the calm indifference of all broken machines, a single grey error code.” Explain, in your own words, what this phrase suggests about the machine's behaviour. [2]

2. The wind is described as “leaning on the walls in long, considering pushes.” What does this language suggest about the wind? [2]

From Paragraph 2

3. Give **two** details from Paragraph 2 that show the narrator was following her training carefully. [2]

4. The narrator writes: “I did not, just yet, think about the word **alone**.” What does the phrase “just yet” suggest about her state of mind at this moment? [1]

From Paragraph 3

5. Why does the narrator say her decision to stay behind had “felt, at the time, simple and rather noble”? Explain what the phrase “at the time” tells us about how her feelings have changed. [2]

From Paragraph 4

6. The narrator says that hearing her own voice “in that quiet was a steadying thing.” Explain why she finds the sound of her own voice comforting. [2]

From Paragraph 5

7. The narrator compares listening to the generator to “the way one listens to a sleeping child whose breathing has briefly changed.” Explain how this comparison makes the moment vivid. Support your answer with **two** details from Paragraph 5. [3]

8. The chair “fell over behind me” and the narrator “did not pick it up.” What does this small detail tell us about her state of mind? [1]

From Paragraph 6

9. The narrator says the fear “had been pure and short and useful.” Explain, in your own words, what she means by calling her fear **useful**. [2]

From Paragraph 7

10. The narrator describes the blizzard as “performing a serious and ancient piece of work.” What impression does this give of the storm? [2]

From Paragraph 8

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: An opinion essay on the ethics of de-extinction — the science of reviving species that humans have driven to extinction.

1

In a laboratory in Dallas, technicians are working to bring the woolly mammoth back. In Melbourne, a separate team is editing the genome of a small marsupial in the hope of producing, within a decade, something close to a thylacine — the Tasmanian tiger, last seen alive in 1936. The science is dazzling, the ambition larger still, and the public response a curious mixture of wonder and unease. We are, it seems, on the verge of something that until very recently belonged to fiction: the deliberate undoing of extinction.

2

The case for de-extinction is, on the face of it, strong. Its supporters argue that bringing back lost species could restore ecological functions long missing from northern grasslands and Australian forests. A mammoth, they suggest, would help maintain the cold, dry steppe that once locked vast quantities of carbon into the permafrost; a thylacine would restore a top predator to an island whose ecosystem has, since its loss, been progressively unbalanced. Beyond ecology, there is what one philosopher has called the argument from **restitution**: where humans drove a species into the dark, humans have a duty, where they can, to switch the light back on.

3

And yet the opposition is, in many ways, more strenuous than the public realises. A growing chorus of conservation biologists has begun to point out, quietly and patiently, that the resources poured into reviving the dead might be better spent rescuing the dying. The black rhinoceros, the Sumatran orangutan, the vaquita porpoise — to name only three — are clinging to existence in numbers that grow smaller every year. A single mammoth project, fully funded, is reported to cost in excess of one hundred and fifty million dollars. The vaquita could be stabilised, ecologists believe, for less.

4

There is also the ecological risk to consider. A revived species is not, strictly speaking, the species it replaces. The mammoth that emerges from a Dallas laboratory will be, at best, an elephant edited to resemble a mammoth: a creature whose behaviour, gut microbiome, and social structure have been guessed at rather than inherited. Releasing such a creature into a tundra it has never known — a tundra that has, in the ten thousand years since the original mammoths walked it, become a very different place — invites consequences that no one, however confident, can fully predict. Conservation history is dense with cautionary tales of well-meaning introductions that went badly wrong.

5

Defenders of the projects have answers, of course. The technologies developed for de-extinction, they point out, are not lost to existing wildlife. The same gene-editing tools that might create a passable mammoth could equally well rescue a coral reef from heat stress, or restore disease resistance to a black-footed ferret population already in genetic free-fall. Money, they argue, is rarely zero-sum: the philanthropists who fund a mammoth project are not, in most cases, the same philanthropists who would otherwise have funded a vaquita. To dismiss the new science is, on this view, to mistake one battle for the whole war.

6

Beneath the technical debate, however, lies a deeper and harder question. What, exactly, do we **owe** a species we have driven out of existence? The thylacine was hunted, on a government bounty, for a hundred years. The mammoth, more controversially, may have been hastened to its end by the spears of early humans. If we accept — and most ethicists now do — that extinction by human hand carries a particular kind of guilt, does that guilt also carry a duty? A duty to **attempt** a restitution, however imperfect,

however expensive? Or is restitution, here, a kind of vanity — an attempt to ease our consciences without altering the habits that produced the harm in the first place?

7

There is no clean answer. Perhaps the most honest position is that de-extinction is neither the salvation its boldest champions describe, nor the distraction its sternest critics fear, but a small, peculiar tool with a small, peculiar place. Used badly, it could absorb funding, attention, and moral seriousness that the living desperately need. Used well — sparingly, humbly, in conversation with the ecologists who tend the still-breathing — it could enlarge our sense of what is repairable. The hard work, the slow and unglamorous work, of keeping species alive in the first place will remain, as it has always been, the larger duty. We should not let the spectacle of resurrection distract us from it.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer describes the public response as “a curious mixture of wonder and unease.” Explain, in your own words, what **each** of these feelings suggests about how the public views de-extinction. [2]

From Paragraph 2

13. According to Paragraph 2, give **two** ecological reasons why supporters argue de-extinction is worthwhile. [2]

14. The writer refers to the philosopher’s “argument from **restitution**.” Explain, in your own words, what this argument claims. [2]

From Paragraph 3

15. Why has the writer placed the words “quietly and patiently” in his description of conservation biologists? What does this suggest about their manner? [2]

16. The writer says that “the resources poured into reviving the dead might be better spent rescuing the dying.” Explain, in your own words, the contrast the writer is drawing in this sentence. [2]

From Paragraph 4

17. The writer says a revived mammoth would be “an elephant edited to resemble a mammoth.” What does this phrase suggest about the writer’s view of the science? [2]

18. Why does the writer mention that “conservation history is dense with cautionary tales”? [1]

From Paragraph 5

19. The defenders of de-extinction argue that “money is rarely zero-sum.” Explain, in your own words, what they mean by this. [2]

From Paragraph 6

20. What is the writer’s **tone** in the question, “Or is restitution, here, a kind of vanity — an attempt to ease our consciences without altering the habits that produced the harm in the first place?” [1]

From Paragraph 7

21. The writer describes de-extinction as “a small, peculiar tool with a small, peculiar place.” What is **effective** about repeating the phrase “small, peculiar”? [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **the arguments against de-extinction** and **the responses given by its defenders**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 3 to 5** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Critics of de-extinction argue that ...

— END OF PAPER —